

Say No Scripts

12 Word-for-Word Ways to Turn Something Down Without Burning the Bridge

Every script below is ready to say or send exactly as written. Swap in names, dates, or details where needed, and use the one that fits the moment.

01

The Straightforward No

When you don't want to give a reason and don't owe one.

"Thanks so much for thinking of me. I'm going to pass on this one."

02

The Capacity No

When your plate is genuinely full and you want that clear.

"I don't have the bandwidth to do this well right now, so I'm going to say no. I'd rather decline than half-do it."

03

The Not-Right-Fit No

When the ask isn't aligned with what you actually do or want.

"This isn't really in my lane these days, so I'll pass. I appreciate you thinking of me though."

04

The Redirect No

When you can't help but know someone who might be able to.

"I can't take this on, but you might try reaching out to [name]. This sounds more in their wheelhouse."

05

The Not-Now No

When the timing is wrong but you want to leave a door open.

"This isn't the right season for me to take this on. Feel free to check back in a few months."

06

The Boundary No

When you need to hold a line without justifying it further.

"That doesn't work for me. I hope you understand."

07

The Grateful Decline

When you want to honor the invitation while still declining.

"I'm honored you asked, and the answer is no for me this time."

08

The Values-Based No

When the ask conflicts with a priority or principle you're protecting.

"I'm being really protective of my time with my family right now, so I have to say no."

09

The Partial Yes

When you want to decline the whole ask but offer something smaller.

"I can't take on the whole project, but I could offer a quick call to point you in the right direction."

10

The Delayed Decision

When you need time before answering, not a script to avoid answering.

"Let me check my schedule and get back to you by [specific day]. I don't want to give you a rushed answer."

11

The Repeat-Ask No

When someone pushes after you've already declined once.

"I hear you, and my answer is still no. I want to be respectful of your time by being clear now."

12

The Warm Close

When you want the no to end on connection, not distance.

"This isn't a yes for me, but I really do value you reaching out. Let's stay in touch."

You said no before you could tie your shoes. It was never a skill you lost,
only permission you stopped giving yourself.

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